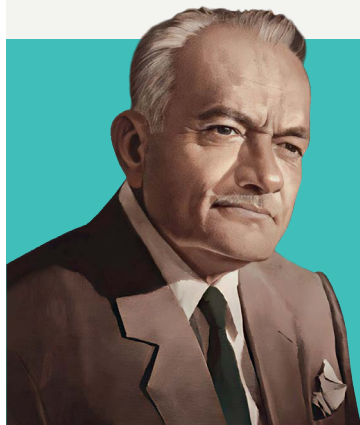


A BRIEF HISTORY



1969

Jayantilal Chauhan buys Bisleri Ltd, an Italian company, from Felice Bisleri



1993

Ramesh Chauhan sells soft drinks portfolio to Coca-Cola



1991

Bisleri introduces the 20-litre pack for both home and office use

1995

Bisleri launches 500-ml bottle at ₹5

1998

Introduces tamper-proof bottle

74 |

two large volume segments, Bisleri has a market share of about 90 per cent. Given its loyal user base cutting across institutions and homes, less money is spent on marketing and advertising.

MAKING THE CHANGE

The company isn't banking just on brand recall. Over the past few years, it has actively nurtured a change in its functioning style.

For a person from the next generation, Chauhan found the earlier system of decision-making a tiresome exercise initially. "It was actually exasperating and it was important to move to one that was more collective," she tells *BT*, in what is her first big interaction with the media. One deterrent was the region-wise structure and that made way for what she says has been a more efficient vertical organisation in 2019.

In 2015-16, it brought EY aboard to give the company a contemporary touch. One of its big recommendations was bringing in a professional CEO for the first time in the company's history. Heeding that advice, family-run Bisleri hired Angelo, an old HUL and Dabur hand, as CEO in mid-2019. "I was young and inexperienced.

I needed someone at that critical stage," says Chauhan, who studied product development at Fashion Institute of Design and Merchandising (FIDM) in Los Angeles.

Understandably, it was not an easy period and the people within took some convincing. "I am quite task-oriented as a person and clear that business will always be a period of learning," she explains.

In terms of plants, the company has an enviable spread now. It has a presence in Odisha, Manipur, Gujarat, Kashmir and down south in Kanyakumari. The largest market is the south, an indication of the higher urbanisation there. "Our target markets are the 8,000 towns in India and not the 600,000 villages," adds Angelo.

On the premium side of the water business, it has Vedica, launched in 2006 as Natural Mountain Mineral Water and relaunched six years later. This one has been a pet project of Chauhan's. It is also sold in glass bottles, apart from the PET (polyethylene terephthalate, a type of plastic that is strong, clear and completely recyclable) version. "There were a lot of people who did not believe in the category but I saw how it was developing in other parts of the world. I was very clear on going for a glass bottle to give the brand a premium image," she